The state of Jammu and Kashmir had more than 500 princely states in the sub-continent under British rule, inhabited by two distinct communities, Muslims and Hindus. The Muslims were the overwhelming majority (80 per cent), especially in the Vale of Kashmir. In 1846, the Hindu Dogra Gulab Singh purchased the Vale of Kashmir from the East India Company (Lamb, 1994). Although these two communities generally lived together in harmony, the 'ethno-communal divisions were present from a very early stage'. The dispute erupted in August 1947 at the time of partition of the sub-continent into two independent states, Pakistan and India. According to the partition plan, the princely states had to join either India or Pakistan on the basis of the religious majority and contiguity to one or the other country. However, the then Prime Minister of India, Jawaharlal Nehru, having profound emotional involvement with Kashmir which was his ancestral land, 'was determined to block the application in any shape or form to his beloved Kashmir of those principles which had brought Pakistan into being' (Malik, 2002). Before the decision of Kashmir's accession could be made in accordance with the wishes of its people, the Hindu ruler of Kashmir arbitrarily signed the instrument for accession with India and the Indian forces forcibly accessed it to India on 27 October 1947 (Lamb, 1994). The people of Kashmir revolted against this arbitrary accession, calling for self-determination. This led to the Indo-Pakistan war to start in 1948. The UN secured a ceasefire and through a resolution called for plebiscite to determine the will of the people of Jammu and Kashmir. Contrary to its commitment, India refused to abide by the UN resolutions (Khan, 2001), thereby resulting in a serious conflict.

During 1989–96, trained intruders were despatched from Pakistan to reinforce the indigenous struggle of Kashmiris against the Indian forces in Indian-held Kashmir (IHK) (Naji, 2011). About a quarter argued that this intrusion was a disservice to the indigenous uprising as their guerrilla activities caused a new wave of violence in IHK. However, it experienced a brutal response from Indian forces. A chain reaction ensued. The militant jihadi organisations grew rapidly and established their training camps in Pakistan-administered Kashmir called Azad Kashmir (liberated Kashmir) by Pakistan. Jihad became a buzzword on this eastern side of Pakistan after raging hard for 10 years across its western borders in Afghanistan.